

Badge Bootcamp v2

Everything you need to know to get started with Open Badges, digital badges, and microcredentials!

Email 0 - you're on the list!

Congratulations for signing up for Badge Bootcamp v2, a new and improved version of We Are Open Co-op original introduction to badges.

Over the next five days you're going to have this course delivered directly to your inbox. So if for some reason this has ended up in your Spam folder or Promotions tab, move it to your inbox to help ensure the next ones get delivered properly!

If you've got any questions or concerns please direct them towards badgebootcamp@weareopen.coop and we'll get back to you at our earliest opportunity.

Finally, this course is free but not cheap. By this we mean that it costs time and money to put together and host this course for you and others. If you'd like to help with the running costs, head over to [Open Collective](#) to chip in. Every dollar/pound/euro/shekel counts!

Email 1 - what are badges?

Whether you call them Open Badges, digital badges, microcredentials, or something else, you're in the right place to learn more! During this email-based course we're going to refer to them simply as 'badges'.

We'll learn a bit more about what makes badges special in the next email, but first let's dive into some examples of badges in the wild.

IBM Skills

 **IBM Skills**

Topics ▾ Professionals ▾ Students Clients Partners Badges About

Select Language ▾

Popular Free Badges

Earning IBM digital credentials drives your career growth and job opportunities. Here are a few of our most popular badges you can earn for free!

↓

[Get more information on IBM Badges →](#)

 Agile Explorer Badge earners will have a foundational understanding of the Agile values, principles, and practices that help change culture and behaviors in the way that people work.	 Enterprise Design Thinking Badge earners know the value of Enterprise Design Thinking, seek opportunities to use it, and can apply its practices in their daily work.	 Working in a Digital World: Professional Skills Badge earners understand, embrace, and successfully practice key soft skills for professional success in the IT workforce.
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<https://www.ibm.com/skills/badges>

IBM are one of the biggest tech companies in the world. They've been using badges for a few years now to recognise skills that are really important to their organisation. Interestingly, they have said publicly that they are [looking to reduce the number of graduates they hire](#), as they find a skill-based approach helps them better attract and retain talent.

Digital Champions



<http://digichamps.co.uk>

London CLC were looking to empower parents, especially immigrant women, through helping improve their digital skills. An important part of this programme was confidence, which they scaffolded through a series of badges which led to a 'Digital Mentor' badge.

CSU Certified Gardener Program



<https://www.online.colostate.edu/badges/certified-gardener/curriculum.dot>

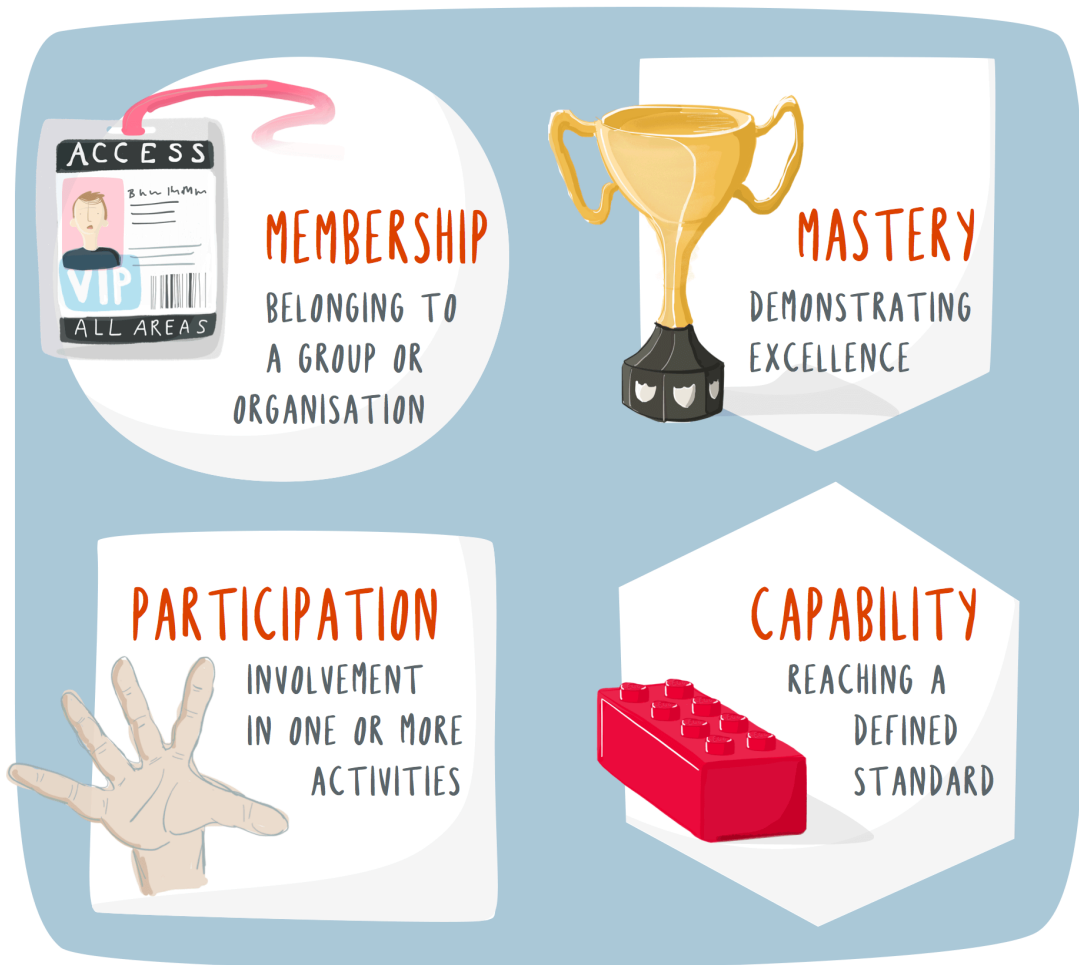
Colorado State University uses a military insignia-style three-level badge system for their Certified Gardener Program. This allows those interested to pick and choose the courses they are interested in ('Trek' badges), bundle their knowledge ('Quest' badges) and then level-up ('Mastery' badge)

A simple badge taxonomy

The wonderful thing about badges is that they can be issued by anyone, for anything. The downside, of course, is that sometimes it can be difficult to think of how they might work in your context.

BADGE TAXONOMY

VO.2
HALF
BAKED



@bryanMathers

THINKING: DOUG BELSHAW & BRYAN MATHERS FOR CITY & GUILDS

This taxonomy outlines common uses of badges. Can you think of ways in which each of these might be represented in your organisation or context? Quite often, people think that badges have to be issued at the *end* of a journey, but what if you issued one at the *start* of a journey? What would that look like?

Next steps...

- Examples of badges
 - IBM (technical skills) — <https://www.ibm.com/skills/badges>
 - Digichamps (confidence) — <http://digichamps.co.uk/earn-digital-badges>

- Cities of Learning (place-based learning) - <https://www.citiesoflearning.co.uk/discover>
- Participate (communities of practice) - KBW badges
- Badge taxonomy
 - EXISTING IMAGE: Badge taxonomy

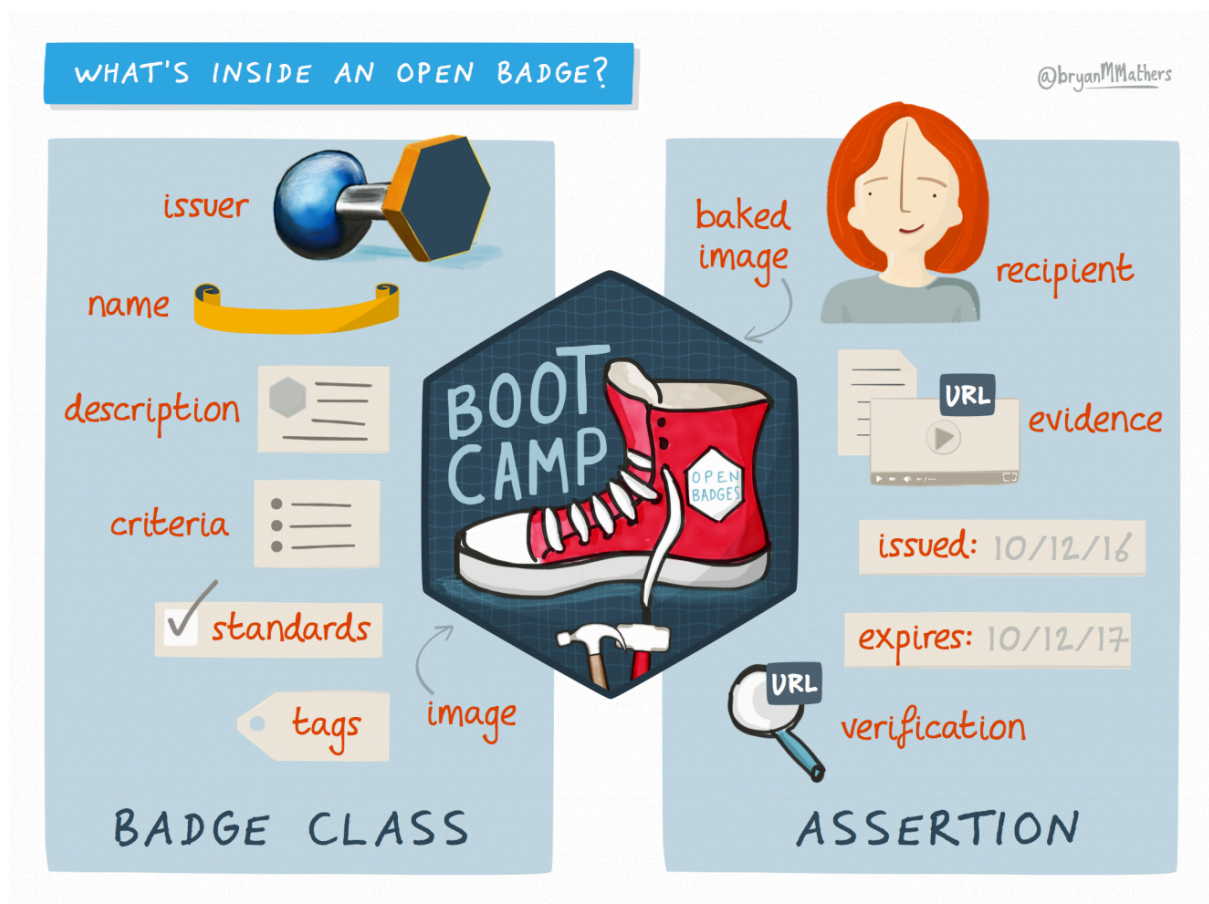
Email 2 - what makes badges special?

The chances are you know the [dictionary definition](#) of a badge:

1. a device or token especially of membership in a society or group
2. a characteristic mark
3. an emblem awarded for a particular accomplishment

So what makes an OPEN badge special? And... can't they be faked? Couldn't you just copy and paste someone else's? 😞

1. Open Badges have metadata inside



Metadata is something we use every day, whether it's tagging someone in a photo on a social network or using the Dewey decimal system in the library. There are two kinds of metadata in an Open Badge:

- **Badge Class** - this is the information that will be the same in every issued badge (*e.g. the name and description*)
- **Assertion** - this is unique to the individual badge earner (*e.g. email address and evidence*)

The metadata is the 'secret sauce' of the badge, meaning that if someone did try and steal someone else's, either the metadata would be incorrect or they would literally just have an image without any information attached!

One way of thinking of it is through the metaphor of making a cake. Just as you can't take the ingredients out after baking, so with a 'baked' badge the image and metadata can't be tampered with after being issued.

2. They're built on an open standard

NEW IMAGE: showing IMS stewardship and ecosystem based on open standard

There is a non-profit called [IMS Global Learning Consortium](#), who are the stewards of many standards and frameworks, including the [Open Badges standard](#). They ensure that everything works on a technical level, and collaborate with organisations to further develop standards.

In the same way that you can visit any website in any web browser, so Open Badges can be moved between systems. You can store them in an online portfolio, on your computer, mobile device, or a storage system like Google Drive!

All badges have the same set of required information. They have a **title**, a **description**, an **issuer**, an **earner**, **criteria** and an **issue date**. You can read more about the technical specification at openbadgespec.org.

There's also some really useful additional information you can include a badge, such as an **evidence** link, **standards alignment**, and an **expiry date**!

3. Anyone can issue badges, for any reason

The **issuer** is the individual or organisation who gives a badge to another individual or organization. Simply put, they're the designer of the badge. You can issue a badge for doing household chores, or for obtaining a PhD. You can issue it to one person or a million people.

Although individuals can and do issue badges to other individuals, most often it's an organisation issuing them to an individual. They can be issued for anything, but usually for:

- **Skills** - 'hard' skills such as technical competence, or 'soft' skills such as collaboration
- **Knowledge / Understanding** - passing a test or otherwise demonstrating understanding of a subject
- **Participation / Membership** - proving that someone attended an event or is (or has been) a member of an organisation

More interesting are badges for recognition, which you might think of as similar to LinkedIn's 'endorsements' feature. The difference with Open Badges is that they're more visual and not tied to one platform.

4. They can be evidence-based

The metadata specification of Open Badges allows an issuer to require evidence in order to obtain a badge. This might be a blog post or a photo, a video, a webpage, a 200 page essay, a 30 second audio clip — anything you can put on the web!

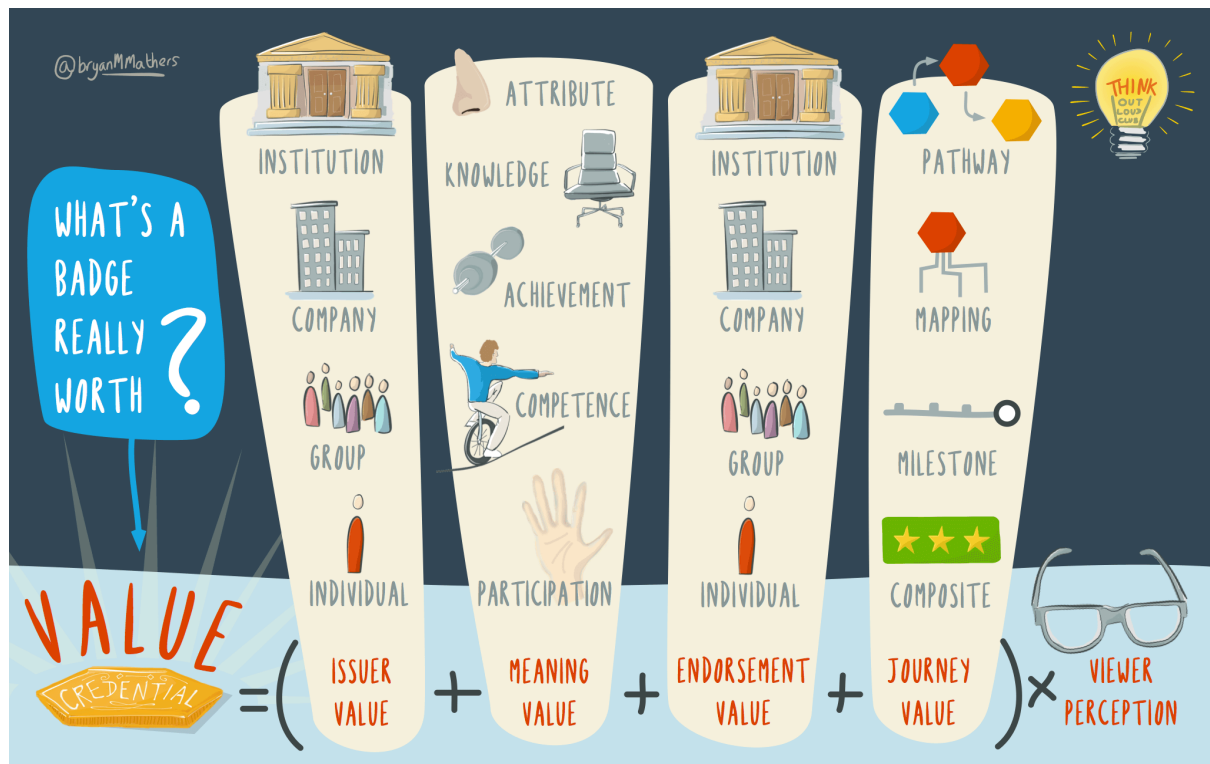
The value of adding evidence is that, for example, you can not only issue a badge to say that someone can build a wall but actually *show them building it* in the evidence link embedded in the badge.

5. Badges can be displayed anywhere on the web

Open Badges work like the web, and can be displayed anywhere. You can put them on your website, on a portfolio, link to them via social networks. They can travel around the web with you!

Email 3 - what's the value of a badge?

Beauty, as they say, is in the eye of the beholder. And the same is at least partly true of badges as well. Check out this image which shows all of the different factors involved in figuring out what a badge is 'really' worth.



The reputation and prestige of the issuer combined with the type of skill gives the badge a certain meaning. Add on an endorsement value, put the badge in the context of a larger learning pathway and show it to someone, and suddenly it takes on a whole new meaning.

Badges can increase or decrease in value over time. For example, a small organisation unknown to most people might create a badge or badge system which turns out to be extremely valuable both to those earning the badges and those looking to recruit them.

Equally, a large prestigious organisation might create a badge or badge system which ends up being meaningless to those earning the badges. Or it might not signal the right value to those viewing the badge(s).

Designing valuable badge system



@bryanMMathers



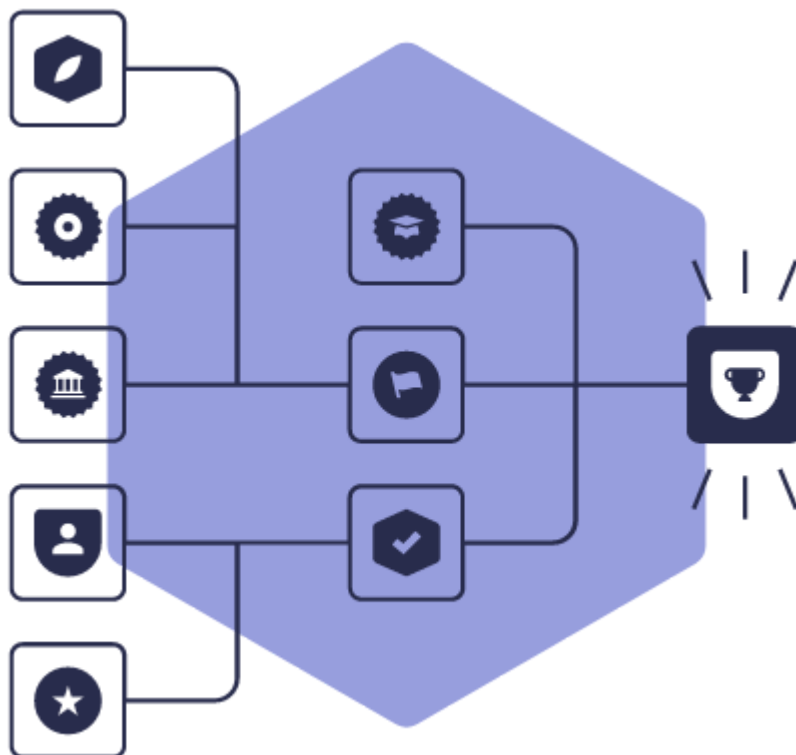
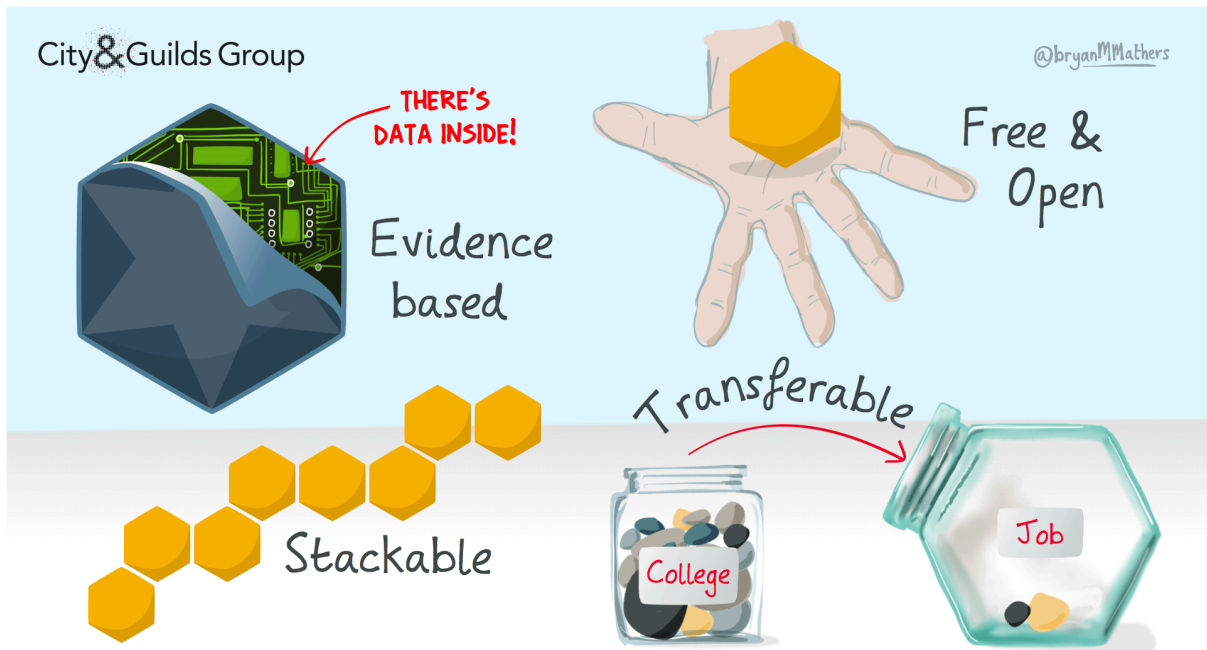
OLD SCHOOL
CREDENTIALS



NEW SCHOOL
CREDENTIALS

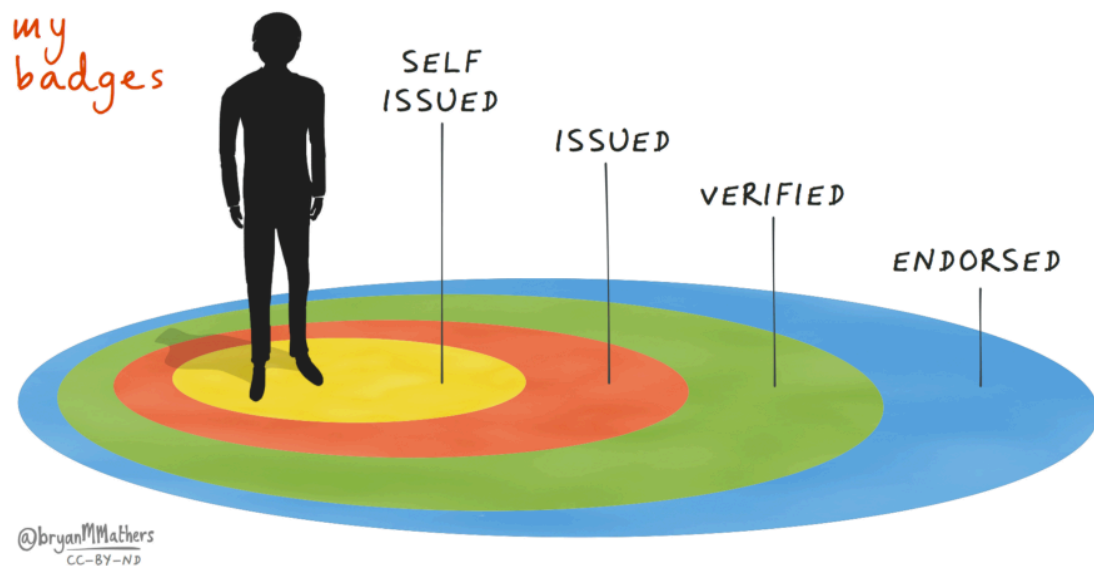
- Different factors (perception / reputation)
 - EXISTING IMAGE: What's the value of a badge?
- Augments existing credentials
 - EXISTING IMAGE: New school credentials image

Email 4 - badge pathways



- Stackable credentials
 - UPDATED IMAGE: why badges are so great (focus on stackable bit)
- Manual vs programmatic pathways
 - EXISTING IMAGE: Screenshot of Badgr/OBF pathways?

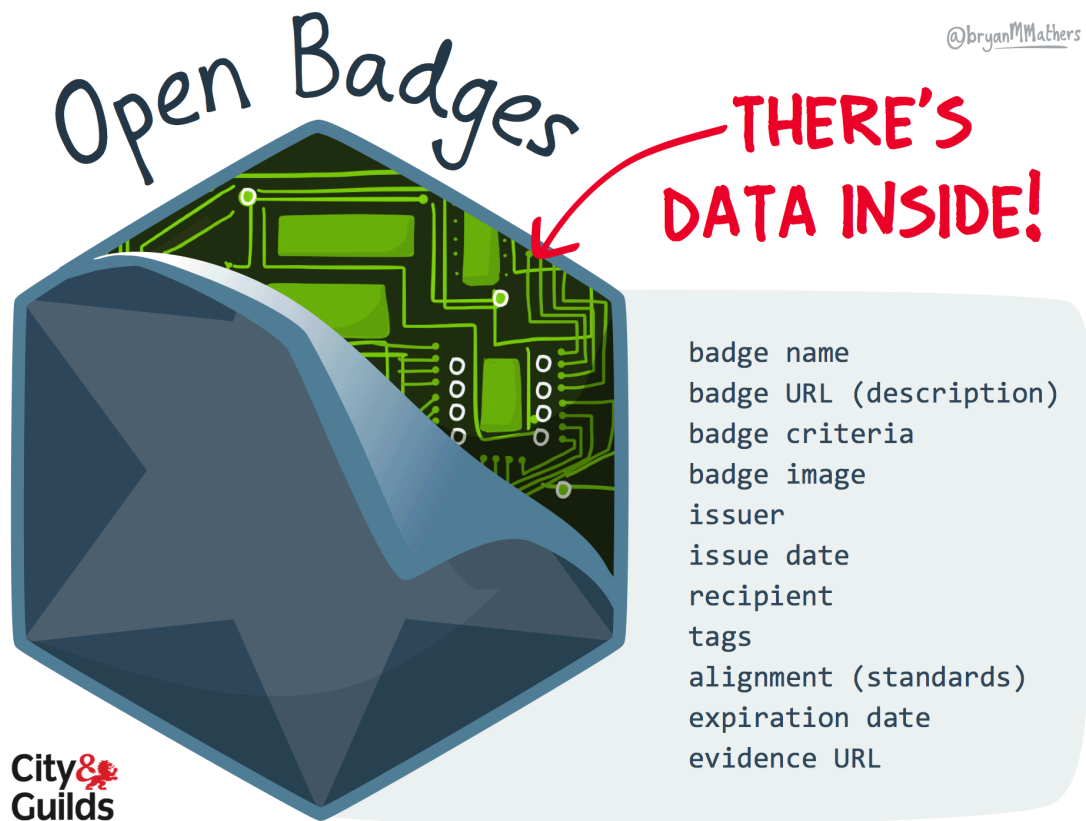
Email 5 - changing mindsets



- Self-issued badges

- EXISTING IMAGE: concentric circles
- Endorsed badges
 - NEW IMAGE: example of an endorsed badge

Final wrap-up email



- CTAs
 - Open Collective - <http://opencollective.org/weareopen>
 - Hire us! - <https://weareopen.coop/contact>
 - Choose a badging system (blog post) - <https://blog.weareopen.coop/10-platforms-for-issuing-open-badges-f249cf609d42>